

GOVIND KARJOL, *73* ▶

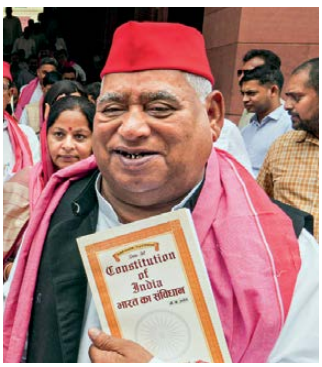
| BJP | ***Chitradurga (SC), Karnataka***

The BJP in Karnataka has cultivated a catchment area extending well beyond the caste elite. A refugee from the old Janata Dal, Karjol exemplifies that social range. His 2004 shift to saffron renewed what finally became a five-term run as MLA from his native northern Karnataka seat of Mudhol. Deputy CM from 2019-2021, his shift to this reserved seat brought redemptive salve after a 2023 rebuff from Dalits.

◀ CHANDRASHEKHAR AZAD, *37*

| AZAD SAMAJ PARTY (KANSHIRAM) | ***Nagina (SC), UP***

Politics, like everything else, lends itself to categories. Here, the man who dared to suffix 'Ravan' to his name rose from the badlands of western UP like a shining knight of emancipatory Dalit politics. His moustachioed, muscular bearing spoke power to the disempowered; a riposte in their own language for the old patricians. Ever since his newborn party made a singlehanded conquest of Nagina—against a quartet of big parties (BJP, SP-Congress,BSP)—he has rightly refused to be boxed into an exclusive 'Dalit' slot, though. Yes, Mayawati's eclipse left a void for him, but he wouldn't have a 51 per cent vote share if the elite castes hadn't preferred him too, he says. Also, that the constitutional rights and values embodied by Ambedkar are meant for all. He exhibited his devotion to those by putting his neck on the line during the anti-CAA days. Shunned by the BSP once, and by the SP now, he bids fair to expand—and not just in UP. His Bhim Army counts 10 million members across India.



▲ AWADHESH PRASAD PASI, *78*

| SP | ***Faizabad, UP***

This is where the script encountered its most heartless twist for the BJP. The new temple in Ayodhya stood, resplendent in its revanchism, right in the heart of this constituency—Hindutva's chief votive offering to its devouts. But for those watching more closely, it wasn't surprising that an old socialist won the kingdom, one who as a young man had thrown himself into the anti-Emergency tumult of the 1970s and been a solid piece of political earth ever since: MLA nine times, state minister six times. Known as the SP's Dalit face, he prefers a more universalist tag. That spirit took him to INDIA's front benches.



R.K. CHAUDHARY, *65*

| SP | ***Mohanlalganj (SC), UP***

A founding member of the BSP who ended up in the SP before the 2022 assembly polls—after a three-year trial period in the Congress—R.K. Chaudhary's win against the BJP's Kaushal Kishore was part of a larger statement Dalits made in UP.



YOGENDRA CHANDOLIA, *62*

| BJP | ***North West Delhi (SC)***

A BJP general secretary for Delhi, Chandolia is the party's local Dalit face. A municipal councillor from Dev Nagar in Karol Bagh, he has also served as the mayor of North Delhi Municipal Corporation.

-Amitabh Srivastava, Prashant Srivastava, Ajay Sukumaran and Avishek G. Dastidar